Akbar would have had, too, though Abu'l Fazl was discreetly silent about this. While Akbar disapproved of his courtiers appearing visibly drunk or even smelling of alcohol in his darbar, he was much more indulgent outside the court. When one Shaikh Abdur Rahim, friend of another notorious drunkard*, from whom 'he had learned wine-drinking', and who 'drank so hard that he got frequently insane', accidentally hurt himself during just such a drunken fit, Akbar himself tended to the wounded man. On another occasion, it was no less than the sadr, Abd ul-Hai, and the chief qazi, who took part in a drinking competition during a feast, and Akbar was so delighted at thus seeing the highest religious and judicial authorities in their cups that he was moved to quote a line of poetry by Hafiz.

Badauni tells us about specific bans brought in to protect the beliefs of the Hindus at this time: 'He prohibited the slaughter of cows, and the eating of their flesh, because the Hindus devoutly worship them.' Anyone accused of cow slaughter or of having killed a peacock was punished by state authorities, long beards were frowned upon, dogs were allowed into the harem, and the hajj pilgrimage and five-times-namaaz were deemed unnecessary. Though an increasing austerity diffused into the Padshah's habits he still, nonetheless, appreciated good food. Hakim Humam in addition to being a doctor, was a calligrapher, scientist, connoisseur of poetry, and also mir bakawal, master of the kitchen. When he had to absent himself on missions, Akbar would complain that 'since Hakim Humam has gone my food has not the same taste'.

For Badauni, who was now only employed for translations and completely excluded from the high-voltage discussions with the Jains, Brahmins and Sufis, it appeared that Akbar only wanted to placate the Hindus. 'He acted very differently in the case of Hindus, of whom he could not get enough,' wrote Badauni bitterly, 'for the Hindus, of course, are indispensable; to them belongs half the army and half the land. Neither the Hindustanis nor the Moghuls can point to such great lords as the Hindus have among themselves. But if other than Hindus came and wished to become disciples at any sacrifice, his Majesty reproved or punished them. For their honour and zeal he did not care, nor did he notice whether they fell in with his views or not.' For Pinheiro, a later Jesuit to Akbar's court, the verdict was even more succinct: 'He adores God, and the Sun, and is a Hindu, he follows the sect of the Jains.' As for the Hindus and Brahmins at court, Akbar fit easily within their capacious pantheon. 'Cheating, thieving